Three Mistakes Families Make While the Help Around Your Mother Is Working

What each one looks like, why it happens, and the easier habit to put in its place.

An arrangement that works rarely gets looked at. Most families make the same three assumptions about it. None of them is about how much anyone cares, and each has an easy habit to put in its place.

1 Waiting until coverage fails

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE The week runs itself, so nobody has written it down. Ask the family who helps your mother and when, and the answer is “we all pitch in.” The plan is to look at it properly once there's a reason to.

WHY IT HAPPENS Help that works is hard to see, and it feels odd to study something that isn't a problem. It is also the usual way care at home is arranged: the federal Administration for Community Living says about 80 percent of it is provided by unpaid caregivers, family members and friends. [1]

> **WHAT TO DO INSTEAD** Pick a quiet week and put it on one page: the days, who comes, what they do. Then show it to your mother and ask what you've missed. AARP's planning guide says a family's plan doesn't have to be extensive or fancy, and should never be made without the participation and knowledge of the person it's about. [2]

2 Assuming family availability will never change

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE “My sister has Tuesdays.” She has had them for years, so the sentence sounds permanent. Nobody has asked her how Tuesdays are going, or what her own next year looks like.

WHY IT HAPPENS Asking can feel like doubting her, or like inviting her to stop. AARP's guide treats it as ordinary: it says team members' ability to help may change, and that a plan should be open to modification when it does. [2]

> **WHAT TO DO INSTEAD** Beside each name on the page, write one line that begins “This works as long as…” Then ask each helper how it's going on their end, and what they are and aren't prepared to do. Write down what they say. You're asking. You aren't reassigning anything. [2]

3 Overlooking the need for a backup caregiver

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE Your sister has never missed a Tuesday, so nobody has ever talked about who else could drive. The neighbor looks in most mornings, and the neighbor's phone number is in your sister's phone and nowhere else.

WHY IT HAPPENS A backup seems unnecessary when the first person is reliable, and asking someone to stand by sounds like a large request. It can be a small one. The Family Caregiver Alliance notes that when jobs are broken down into very simple tasks, it is easier for people to help. [3]

> **WHAT TO DO INSTEAD** For each role, write who could cover for a week, or write “nobody identified yet.” A backup doesn't have to be a relative: AARP says not to overlook friends, colleagues, clubs and religious or other groups, and that team members need not live nearby or have huge blocks of time to be of value. Then ask one person whether they'd be willing in principle. Nobody is a backup until they've said yes. [2]

The one habit behind all three

Write the week down and ask the three questions this step asks: where are the gaps, who could help if the usual person can't, and what should we raise now. Put the answers on the page, and let each person answer for themselves.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't say whether your mother's arrangement is enough, who should do what, or what help to add. It names three assumptions, the same three the Family Care Roadmap sees at this step, and a habit for each.

Ready for the next step?

You know which three assumptions to look at, and the habit for each. The care interview adds the structured look: it asks about supervision, falls, medication handling, the home and each helper's capacity in a set order, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

The 80 percent figure is the Administration for Community Living's. The advice about a simple plan, changing availability and where to look for helpers is AARP's, and the point about breaking jobs into simple tasks is the Family Caregiver Alliance's. The three mistakes are the Family Care Roadmap's own.

1. Administration for Community Living, Who Will Provide Your Care?
2. AARP, Prepare to Care: A Planning Guide for Families
3. Family Caregiver Alliance, Taking Care of YOU: Self-Care for Family Caregivers

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